

The Gibson Desert

A hostile, largely untouched sandy desert in the center of Western Australia



△ BIG RED

Australia's largest living marsupial, the red kangaroo, is common in the Gibson Desert. Adaptations such as hopping conserve energy and minimize contact with hot sand.

Bordered by three other deserts—the Great Sandy (to the north), the Little Sandy (west), and the Great Victoria (south)—the Gibson is one of Australia's most pristine deserts, protected from human impact by its hot, harsh conditions. Few people live here—not surprisingly, given that it is named for an explorer, Alfred Gibson, who perished trying to

cross it in 1874. The desert is 60,250 square miles (156,000 square km) of mostly low, undulating dune fields and sandy plains. There are also gravel ridges, formed of pebbles coated in iron oxide, and small saline lakes. Despite summer temperatures of 104°F (40°C) and little water, animals such as kangaroos and emus manage to survive.

▷ YELLOW BLOOM

When rain does fall, the Gibson Desert's sand supports thousands of tufts of yellow spinifex grass, one of the few plants able to germinate here.



The Pinnacles

A jagged landscape, with thousands of stone pillars rising out of yellow desert sand, continually covered and uncovered, and all born of rainwater and plant roots



In the center of Western Australia's Nambung National Park lies a coastal desert with a difference. The Pinnacles is the name given to thousands of limestone pillars, rising out of a landscape otherwise covered by sand dunes. How the pillars formed, or why they formed here and not in any other coastal dune environment, is still a subject of debate. However, what is known is that about 30,000–25,000 years ago, they began as crushed seashells, which eventually turned into limestone beneath a dune system.

Root cause

As vegetation developed in the area, rainwater leached through enriched acidic soil, causing a hardened layer to form on top of the softer limestone. Plant roots eventually forced their way down through cracks in this hardpan, setting off a vertical erosion process in the limestone. As winds shifted the sand dunes in a drying climate, the first pinnacles were revealed.



◁ ROCK SPIRES

Most of the pinnacles are 3–6 ft (1–2 m) high, but some reach a height of 16 ft (5 m). Winds continually shift the dunes, covering some pinnacles and revealing others.